- Targeted assassinations of members of the leadership are, in my view, a very effective strategy in general, but not a sufficient one.
- True deterrence occurs only when the adversary understands that the steps it is taking are illogical, as not only will they not achieve its goal, but they will even lead to negative results in areas that really matter to it. Here again, the question arises of whether this definition applies to an adversary that is irrational.
- Will the mechanisms that have been in place in the nuclear arena since the Cold War—safeguards and permissible access links— be accepted by the Iranians if and when they obtain nuclear weapons?
- To what extent will the taboo on using a nuclear bomb, which has existed since World War II, be maintained by the Iranians, or at least be an additional consideration for them? The conflict that comes closest to testing this taboo today is the Indian-Pakistani conflict. The conventional theory is that both sides having nuclear capacity acts as a moderating force. In the case of Iran, the question is whether the divine command of self-sacrifice for the sake of the global Islamic caliphate will lead to the violation of the taboo or whether it will be preserved despite this edict.
- During the Cold War, the messages conveyed between the two powers took the form of actions, except for the Cuba crisis, during which President Kennedy conveyed his messages via declarations. In a nonstate situation, declarations are the only means of communicating with the adversary, and their influence, by definition, is weaker than actions that display strength. A situation in which the adversaries are nonstate actors refers to the possibility that terrorist organizations will gain control of, or be given by a state, nuclear weapons, be they advanced or not.

Khamenei is becoming weaker in relation to the IRGC. As discussed, the regime is increasingly assuming the character of a pretorian regime in which the IRGC is controlling the political leadership by taking over of the centers of power—the security services, the economy, and the channels through which information is passed to the leader. IRGC members are being appointed to key positions in both the president’s administration and the